

Rattus norvegicus

Brown rat

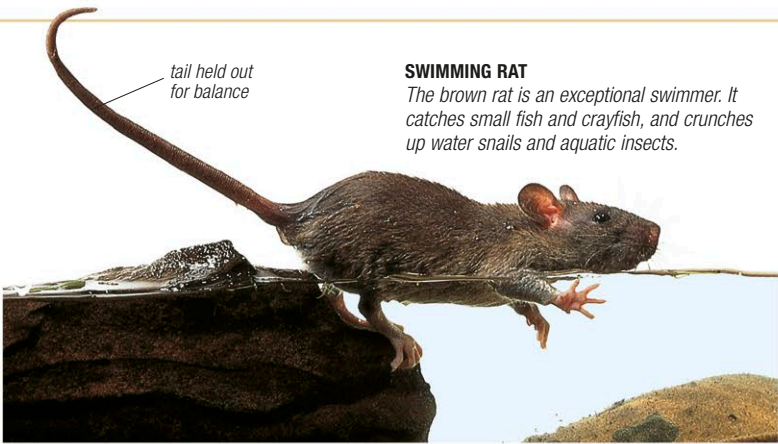


Length 8–11 in (20–28 cm)
Tail 7–9 in (17–23 cm)
Weight 10–21 oz (275–575 g)
Location Worldwide (except polar regions)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



A hugely varied, opportunistic diet, sharp senses, and great agility have enabled the brown rat, also called the Norway or common rat, to spread all around the world. “Packs” of up to 200, dominated by large males, will attack rabbits, large birds, and even fish. After a gestation of 22–24 days, the female gives birth to 6–9 young in a nest of grass, leaves, paper, rags, or almost any other material. This species is the ancestor of rats bred as pets and for scientific research.

COLORATION
The brown rat varies from brown to gray-brown or black on its back. It is paler on the underside, and has a long, sparsely haired tail.



SWIMMING RAT
The brown rat is an exceptional swimmer. It catches small fish and crayfish, and crunches up water snails and aquatic insects.



Leporillus conditor

Greater stick-nest rat



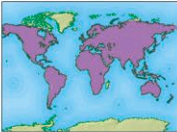
Length 7–10 in (17–26 cm)
Tail 5¼–9½ in (14.5–24 cm)
Weight 5½–16 oz (150–450 g)
Location W. and S. Australia
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable



Occurring naturally on Franklin Island, W. Australia, and introduced elsewhere, the greater stick-nest rat is almost rabbit sized, with long ears, a rounded nose, and slim, hairy tail. It is gray-brown above and white below, and builds a strong surface nest of sticks and twigs up to 5 ft (1.5 m) high. Large nests may contain many individuals. Active at night, this species feeds on succulent plants and drinks little if any water.

Mus musculus

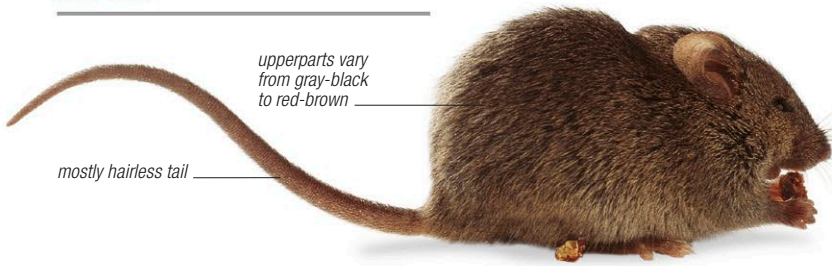
House mouse



Length 2¾–4¼ in (7–10.5 cm)
Tail 2–4 in (5–10 cm)
Weight ½–1 oz (10–35 g)
Location Worldwide (except polar regions)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The second most widely distributed mammal, after humans, this mouse survives on a huge range of foods and lives in a family group of dominant male and several females. They communicate by high-pitched squeaks and mark their territory with scent and urine. Maturity is at 8–10 weeks, gestation 18–24 days, and litter size 3–8, with 10 litters in favorable years. The species has been widely bred for pets and scientific research.



Hydromys chrysogaster

Common water rat



Length 11½–15½ in (29–39 cm)
Tail 9–13 in (23–33 cm)
Weight 1½–3 lb (0.65–1.25 kg)
Location New Guinea, Australia (including Tasmania)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern



Australia's heaviest native rodent has broad back feet and webbed toes, for swimming. The upperparts vary from brown to gray, the underparts brown

to golden-yellow, cream, or even white, and the tail is thick and white-tipped. This water rat is active at dusk and dawn as a powerful predator of shellfish, water snails, fish, frogs, turtles, birds, mice, and even bats.



Notomys alexis

Spinifex hopping mouse



Length 3½–7 in (9–17 cm)
Tail 5–9 in (12.5–23 cm)
Weight 1¼–1¾ oz (20–50 g)
Location W. and C. Australia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Also called the dargawarra, this large mouse is named after the bushy, spiky desert grass called spinifex, where it often lives. It obtains all its moisture from leaves, seeds, berries, and other plant foods, never needs to drink, and produces some of the most concentrated urine of any rodent. Very sociable, this mouse lives in mixed-sex groups of up to 10, shares nests, and breeds soon after any rainfall.

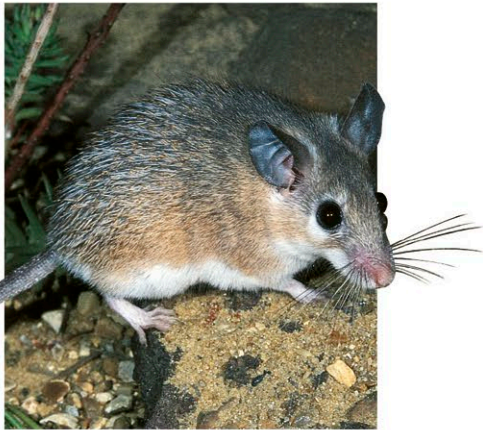


Acomys minous

Crete spiny mouse



Length 3½–4¼ in (9–12 cm)
Tail 3½–4¼ in (9–12 cm)
Weight ¾–3¼ oz (11–90 g)
Location Europe (Crete)
Social unit Variable
Status Data deficient



Coarse, stiff hairs on the back and tail give this mouse its common name. Its fur varies from yellow to red, gray, or brown above, and white below. A nocturnal forager, it takes anything edible—mainly grass blades and seeds—and builds only a rudimentary nest. A gregarious species, gestation is 5–6 weeks (long for a mouse). Other females clean and assist the mother at the birth, when the young are already well developed, with open eyes.